GAMSA · Gender-Affirming Medicines South Australia

PBS Authority for testosterone in gender-affirming care: how it is worded

A one-page card for prescribers and pharmacists · gamsa.au/clinicians

The situation

There is no PBS listing for gender affirmation. Every PBS testosterone item is listed for androgen deficiency and needs an Authority prescription. Written as a private script, the same product can cost several times the co-payment (the full PBS price alone is $78 to $106), so the paperwork is the single biggest lever on what the patient pays.

Who can prescribe on the PBS

The restriction requires that the patient is treated by, in consultation with, or waiting on an appointment with a specialist general paediatrician, paediatric endocrinologist, urologist, endocrinologist or a Fellow of the Australasian Chapter of Sexual Health Medicine. The specialist's name goes on the Authority application. The specialist consultation only needs to happen once; that specialist's name can be used on later Authority applications. Once that is in place, a GP or nurse practitioner can write the PBS script.

The indication used

> The Australian position statement (MJA 2019) uses the authority indication **"androgen deficiency due to an established testicular disorder"**: the patient is treated by or in consultation (including by phone or email) with a paediatrician, endocrinologist, urologist or sexual health physician, whose name goes on the authority application.

Each PBS item page gives the full criteria (select **Criteria**). Use the androgen deficiency restriction whose criterion reads "Patient must have an established pituitary or testicular disorder", not the one for people aged 40 or over. Check the current wording at the time of prescribing.

Before the patient reaches the counter

- [ ] Specialist consultation or pending appointment documented, name recorded
- [ ] Authority obtained (online or phone) and number on the script
- [ ] Formulation and strength match the PBS item (long-acting undecanoate injection, gel or cream; short-acting injections are not PBS-listed)
- [ ] Patient told the script is PBS Authority, and what the wording will say

What the wording means, and does not mean

Read plainly, the indication describes a pituitary or testicular disorder that stops the body making enough testosterone. It is a listing written long before gender-affirming care was considered and never rewritten. It does not mean the prescription is wrong, that the prescriber has invented anything, or that the patient's entitlement or price is different.

A line to use at the counter

> *"The PBS has no listing written for gender-affirming care, so testosterone is subsidised under its androgen deficiency indication. The wording is a funding category, not a description of you. Your price and your entitlement are the same as for anyone on a PBS Authority script."*

Other hormone medicines

Estradiol, spironolactone and cyproterone (its packs of 50) are General Schedule items and need no Authority. Estradiol patches are often in short supply; check gamsa.au/supply before telling a patient a product is unavailable.

Sources: Pharmaceutical Benefits Scheme item listings and restriction criteria for testosterone products (pbs.gov.au, checked 18 October 2026); Cheung AS et al. Position statement on the hormonal management of adult transgender and gender diverse individuals. Med J Aust 2019;211(3):127–133; AusPATH. Australian Standards of Care for Informed Consent Gender-Affirming Hormone Therapy, version 2 (2026), p33 (auspath.org.au). Patient explanation and references: gamsa.au/costs. Not medical advice; the PBS Schedule in force on the day governs.

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